

THE MANY NAMES GIVEN TO PAULDING COUNTY

by Mrs. Isaac Thomas

Long before 1492, the Vikings had explored the St. Lawrence River and part of the Great Lakes. By 1535, French fur traders and Jesuit priests traveled from Mackinac to the Ohio River. They called Northwestern Ohio **THE BLACK SWAMP** because the huge trees were so close that they shut out the sun.

Maps of this era called the Great Lakes area New France. After the gulf coast was settled, along with some settlements up the Mississippi, the French government called the land from the gulf to the Great Lakes, Louisiana. For governmental purposes, this large area was divided into four parts. The northeast section had their headquarters in Ohio.

In the meantime, the English king granted some of the eastern colonies land reaching to "the great sea." So the southern boundary went along the southern boundary of Paulding County. This put us into Connecticut.

The state of Virginia was given a wedge-shaped area, narrow at the coast and spreading ever wider. This put us into Virginia also.

All early trade, travel, and communication was along the Maumee River to Toledo and Detroit. After General Rogers took the Maumee River area and Detroit in 1761, this became a part of Quebec.

In 1784 and 1785, the Continental Congress passed some laws concerning this area, which they called the Northwest Territory, as the western edge of the country was along the Mississippi River.

The framers of the United States Constitution met in 1787. While they were hammering out the details of the constitution, they passed the Northwest Ordinance to rule the area north of the Ohio River. This granted many personal freedoms unknown in the world at that time. It also listed requirements and procedures for organizing a state.

Ohio became a state in 1803. Now this area was part of Ohio. One of the first counties to organize was Wayne County. This took in the land now occupied by 26 counties, from Wooster on west. We were part of Wayne County. Soon after this, Paulding County was named. But it was 20 years until a government was set up. From 1824 to 1839, Defiance, county seat of Williams County, handled all matters of law.

Paulding County was organized in 1839. County offices were established at New Rochester, on the Maumee River and along the mail line from Fort Wayne to Defiance. It was the largest village in the county at that time.

In 1841, the county seat was moved to Charloe on the promise of a big new courthouse. Charloe is on the banks of the Auglaize River.

The county seat was moved to Paulding in 1855, largely because it was more centrally located. It has been there ever since.

In 1845, the Williams County seat was now at Bryan. After some unrest among the settlers in the southern part of Williams County, it was decided to form Defiance County. This was accomplished by taking land from three surrounding counties. Paulding County gave up half of Auglaize Township (18 sections). Then Paulding County was reorganized to give Auglaize Township four sections from Emerald Township.

Ten of our twelve townships have 36 sections (square miles). Emerald has 32 sections, and Auglaize has 22.



The Old Brick, the oldest standing home in Paulding County was built in 1832 by John Hudson. Still in the family, the principle owner is T. Frank Kohart whose grandson, Rick Hodges, state representative, 82nd district, contributes the 'Long Line From Columbus' column in The Senior's Beacon.